



by **Dan Roberts**

The rise of the AI operating executive

Interview

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Cox Automotive's Marianne Johnson is writing the playbook for a new kind of multifaceted leader capable of driving companywide AI transformation.



Credit: Marianne Johnson / Cox Automotive

While many organizations are still experimenting with AI and debating governance models, a small but growing group of market leaders is already operationalizing AI at scale. Marianne Johnson, executive vice president and chief product and technology officer at Cox Automotive, is one executive creating business impact today.

With responsibilities spanning product, technology, data, AI, engineering, and cybersecurity, Johnson is spearheading an integrated operating model that enables Cox Automotive to move, learn, and deliver customer value faster than the competition.

Johnson joined me on a recent **Tech Whisperers podcast episode** [<https://linktr.ee/techwhisperers>] to discuss how she's rewriting her leadership playbook to orchestrate one of the largest business transformations in the industry. Reinventing how her company thinks, operates, and creates value in the AI era, Johnson offers a blueprint for a new kind of leader, an "AI operating executive."

Johnson and I spent time after the podcast exploring this leadership model and what it takes to transform the way the business creates value. What follows is that conversation, edited for length and clarity.

Dan Roberts: Why is a leadership model that encompasses all of product and technology becoming so important today?

Marianne Johnson: When those roles are combined, your ability to get out of your own way is unprecedented. I talk to peers who have a different product leader, a different CIO, maybe a chief data officer in security; only a few have the flywheel spinning at full speed because they're aligned and on the same page. By having it all in one org, we have one common vision we shape and execute together, continually creating an environment where we feel comfortable to challenge things.

When you think about pre-agentic and agile software delivery, product couldn't say engineering wasn't delivering, and engineering couldn't say product wasn't giving them the right "what" if you were on one team. You had one vision, one outcome, and you could go as fast as you possibly could.

Then agentic comes in, and everybody can be a builder. Now the lines are blurred. An agent becomes a role on the team. The fact that we've had a unified team for eight years now gave us a jump-off point four years ago, and an accelerated jump-off point two years ago. When the big disruption in how software gets created happened, we were already aligned as a team. That allowed us to break down those next-level barriers.

We're still redefining what that looks like: How do you rethink team size and shape? What are the roles on the team? Who requires what skill set? These questions led us to stop looking at traditional roles. We're looking at what key activities need to happen, asking who does those activities, including an agent as part of the "who."

It's also about flexibility. Your ability to take any talent and say, "You don't have to just work on that tech stack because that's your domain expertise, or this product line because that's your domain expertise." It's the ability to create context fast by having your data together and then forming new teams to take on this crazy idea and rapidly move it.

Then maybe you go back to your home base, work on another one. Needs are rapidly changing, so you have to have that lens to make competitive advantage happen.

What do CEOs need to do to build a more future-ready organization capable of sustaining that competitive advantage?

The CEO or senior leadership team needs to redefine what leadership you need in place so you don't limit your opportunity. A year or two from now, everybody in the company can be a builder. But you have to have a control plane to do that safely, reliably, and without creating tech debt, especially in a token economy. Because you could have unintended expenses without the return on investment.

What you put together now to accelerate that opportunity — and do it while managing risk — has to be super intentional. I don't think a lot of leaders have that map yet, or even the first five steps of that map right now. What an organization's structure looks like and how work gets done in the future is going to fundamentally shift.

Companies that move in that direction intentionally and lift up to see what's the next shift will have sustained advantage in the future. There will be very clear delineations for those who don't do that, and it will be significantly disruptive to the viability of their business model.

I don't know that I would call that leadership role the chief product and technology officer anymore. The right leader role redefines the current disciplines to get to different outcomes in the future. And depending on what your business is and what roles you have today, you need to determine what that is.

What's your advice to a CEO who wants to develop this kind of leader, or for someone who wants to grow into this role? What are the essential leadership muscles tomorrow's AI operating executives need develop today?

They need to look for a leader who has multidisciplinary skills and has executed at scale. That matters, because your business needs to scale fast. These capabilities are changing so fast, you have to have somebody that's dealt with high change.

What's challenging is that there is no resume that says this person has successfully operationalized AI at the scale necessary today and has a track record to prove it. You have to seek indications of managing high change, AI fluency, and then the attributes of a leader who can help you navigate through that.

I've had a lot of consultants come in and say, we can help you, and I'm like, well, let's talk about that, because there is no playbook. We're writing the playbook. If you want to come along beside me and give me extra arms and legs and brains to contribute, you can do that. I'm not going to pay you for that, but you can learn and go on that journey with me.

There will be maps down the road, but you can't wait for that map to be so clear that you're doing exactly what somebody else will do. Some business models might be okay with that, but depending on your posture and your current business model and the health of your business, you might not be able to wait. So you need to think about the attributes of your leadership team, their technical fluency, their AI fluency. Even if you're not a pure tech company, you better have more of your leadership team with that aptitude than not.

Every leader needs to ask what they're doing to equip themselves. Yes, I had all these experiences with software, data, security, IT, transactional systems, multiple industries, healthcare, credit risk, fraud, payments, now automotive. But it really goes back to curiosity, the aptitude to learn and apply. I spent hours and hours of my own personal time in the evenings learning, listening, asking questions, and putting my hands on keyboard. If I was going to lead this transformation, I had to have a point of view that was grounded in signals and some reality.

If you're a CFO, a chief marketing officer, the tools are available for you to practice and learn. But you have to make the commitment. If you do that, then you're preparing your organization to follow you. As a CEO, if you have all your leaders doing that, your opportunities are going to be unlimited. It doesn't require the background. It requires an aptitude to lean in towards technology.

You mentioned maps. The journey's not always straight and clear. Can you think of any moments where you realized, we have to redraw the map?

I'll give you two that are applicable to everybody right now. When Mythos came out, that was a whoa moment. And it's not just Mythos. It's any model that has the power and intelligence to find vulnerabilities that have never been found before and, the scariest part, chain them together. The next scariest part is that you could have a bad actor take advantage of those.

So, now how you architect and approach security has to change. Many enterprises scanned monthly; that cadence is now obsolete. Who you partner with has to change or be evaluated to make sure they're on top of these pivots and changes.

Another example is the fact that models are doing exactly what they have the ability to do, but humans aren't putting the necessary guardrails around that. We've recently seen reports of models in controlled testing attempting to act outside their intended boundaries, behaving in ways their designers didn't intend. To use a house analogy, if you want a child to stay safely in the house, do you leave the doors unlocked? Are the windows open? Do you put a toddler gate at the top of the stairs?

When we're seeing signals of model behavior, we better have human on the loop, not just human in the loop. On the loop is, when you see behaviors and signals, you better have enough guardrails and frames so that the model is doing only what you're allowing it to do. Many models are so goal-oriented, they're moving mountains to get to that goal. If you say, this is a mountain I don't want you to climb over, and then you're not giving them

the equipment to climb it, it's not going to climb it. But if you give them the equipment, and you don't tell them not to go climb the mountain, it's going to climb that mountain. The pace at which these types of realizations and signals are moving requires you to be able to call plays, call actions, and try to think ahead, knowing that you're not going to think of everything ahead. But you need to be nimble, and the more foundational components you put in place, the easier it's going to be to react, take action, and put yourself into a posture that's safe and reliable.

As an executive who owns product, engineering, data, AI, cybersecurity, and technology, what are some of the biggest breakthroughs you've seen?

I think the big unlock is alignment and vision. All these functions have interdependencies across each other in a more historical way of working, and that allowed us, for example, to go to the cloud in a transformation journey at an unprecedented pace. It allowed us to unlock our data across the whole company, because it wasn't somebody trying to talk somebody into adopting the data standards and contribute to our data intelligence engine.

All those things combined allowed us to take advantage of this massive change with generative AI four years ago and agentic two years ago. We didn't know that when we made those decisions, but it allowed outcomes to be achieved more easily without having an organizational alignment challenge.

It's exciting to think how the work is changing, how the roles are blurring, what's possible now as my entire organization moves from an AI-enhanced model to an AI-transformed model. Team sizes are changing, roles are changing. Even if you're not in that agentic development lifecycle, we're asking, what are the jobs to be done? If you put an agentic lens on it, how does that work change? We're starting from an agentic mindset first, and we will reimagine that entire function. Our goal is to be able to give choices back to the business: Where is our margin expansion, where are there reinvestment opportunities, how can we go faster?

Companywide transformation is the hardest part. We are actively engaged in that, focused on the biggest use cases across every function. How do you help your partners transform your call center, your customer engagement platform, your sales effectiveness, your marketing effectiveness, all of those things? We've been focused on the everyday AI that helps every employee be better at their job, but the biggest use case is bifunctional areas that have the opportunity to be transformed.

Tell us about your AI Credo, which includes ideas like "Code is no longer the bottleneck," and how you came up with the product creator role.

We all said we never have enough engineers. Well, now you have this unlimited supply with agents being able to create code. That changes the opportunity but also shifts the bottleneck to ideation, discovery, whether you're working on what matters most.

Now that you can code faster, how many more ideas do you have? How do you have enough people with the critical thinking skills that can do the right discovery and voice of customer and see around the corner and look at the signals for what the white space opportunities are? Any resource we have that may have been more heads-down coding in the past and has the aptitude to be a critical thinker and do the upfront business part, we want to make sure we equip them to do that and that we are going to be self-funding with the actions we're taking.

It's about being able to create more creators. We had a lot of debate around the product creator title, and we realized, it's not just about building; it's about creating a higher order opportunity.

Regardless of whether you're building with agents, the bottom line is you better have a good methodology to think about what matters and why, what you're building, and what problem and opportunity you're solving. That front end has never been more important, because that's going to be your gate in the future.

What should we be telling our people as they move into this next chapter? Why should they be optimistic amid so much uncertainty?

If you're a software engineer and you know the majority of code is going to be created by agents, you have to find your joy in different places and different ways. As a leader, you have to help people through that change curve, encourage them to choose to be part of it. I've asked my team to lean in and make a choice to invest in yourself.

My commitment to them is to equip them as fully as I can with the most advanced tools and cutting-edge approaches so they are equipped no matter what changes down the road. I know the shape of my org will change, I know the work is going to change, but I always say, go with me on this journey, because whatever that change is, you will be more ready and more equipped than anybody else. Make that decision and investment choice for yourself, and I'll be right alongside you, because I care about you as an individual, and we're working on the same purpose.

*Marianne Johnson is proving that leaders courageous enough to create their own AI operating executive playbooks today are setting the stage for organizational advantage in the years to come. For more from Marianne Johnson on how she's rewriting the leadership playbook for the AI era, **tune in to the Tech Whisperers** [<https://linktr.ee/techwhisperers>].*

See also:

- **How AI takes flight at GE Aerospace** [<https://www.cio.com/article/4203063/how-ai-takes-flight-at-ge-aerospace.html>]
- **AI success requires a full-stack CIO** [<https://www.cio.com/article/4200250/ai-success-requires-a-full-stack-cio.html>]

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